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Tom Baker

Jazz in Australia is alive and well with players like Tom Baker. Tom is a native Californian but has resided in Australia since the age of 19. A multi-instrumentalist and singer, his enthusiasm on stage makes him a sought after player at jazz gatherings around the world. His self stated mission is to keep the Swing music of the '30s and '40s alive, and he leads two traditional jazz bands at home. He has recorded for Stomp Off and Arbors Records and recently teamed up with Australian jazz legend Bob Barnard for his latest CD. He is also famous in jazz circles for his Mexican, French and Indian culinary creations.

Tom was interviewed on September 13, 1997 at the Allegheny Jazz Party in Chautauqua, New York by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe and it's my pleasure to have Tom Baker as my guest here in Chautauqua, New York. Welcome.

TB: Thanks, Monk.

MR: World traveler. And how long have you been coming back and forth from Australia?

TB: Well I started, well I was born in California and I moved down there when I was about 19 with my family. That was 1972. And a few years later I started coming back and forth because my parents, they moved back to the States, and I stayed, playing in jazz bands.

MR: And how old were you then?

TB: Nineteen or twenty.

MR: Did you start playing pretty quickly when you got there?

TB: Yeah. Almost right away. The thing was I was enrolled in a conservatory here in Stockton, California, called the University of the Pacific. Its main claim to fame was that Dave Brubeck went there. So after going there for six months, after junior college, the parents announced one day to my brother and I that we were going to emigrate to Australia. We said yeah, that's fine. And a few months later, there we went. We'd sold the farm, we had a farm with milk cows and all of that. We sold the farm and down we went. And none of us had ever been there.

MR: What was the reason for it?

TB: Well my father had been in the Marine Corps and he'd sailed over from a long time ago, in the '30s apparently he went to Shanghai in some kind of not the Boxer rebellion maybe it was, one of those 1930s things where the Marines had to go to China to quell some kind of rebellion. But he sailed in his ship from San Francisco to Shanghai and he really loved sailing, even though he was probably down in the bottom. And he wanted to build a

sailboat, that was his dream, and build it in Australia and sail back to America. That was a big thing.

MR: That sounds like something you read about in the *National Geographic*, you know?

TB: Yeah. Well it never happened. His health got bad and we couldn't finish the boat for one reason or another, and after a couple of years the rest of my family moved back to California, which was just as well because I don't really like sailing.

MR: It's a long trip.

TB: I mean how would you be — yeah, from Sydney to Santa Barbara, through the Suez Canal and the Mediterranean and across the Pacific and across the Atlantic, and then through the Gulf of Mexico. And I could only sail for two or three hours and you've had all the sandwiches and you've kind of done the sails a few times, and you think well, gee I wish I was on the land again where I could go and play. So anyway that's how I got down to Sydney and why I stayed.

MR: What was it in your childhood that attracted you to being a musician, playing so many instruments and gravitating —

Hold on [Phone ringing]

MR: Was there something in your childhood, in your family situation that attracted you to jazz music?

TB: Very late in life. We had a piano in the family. It was my brother, myself and my mother and father. That's all there was, in a country house, on a farm, in Central California. That gives you the setting. No musical influences at all — there was no bands apart from the high school band. My parents listened to the usual run-of-the-mill, middle-of-the-road Tijuana Brass, Roger Miller, Al Hirt — you know, the usual things that people had in their record collections in those days. Hugo Winterhalter, I remember him.

MR: A little Mantovani perhaps?

TB: Mantovani was there, yep, and we had a piano and I was made to take piano lessons, but I really loved playing piano, so I took piano lessons from an early age, classical piano, from about age five for a few years. And after that really got into other things, and in high school took up the trumpet. And I really hadn't heard any jazz at all, until one day, this was actually a day when there was a parade, and it was called The Fate, in the middle of our little town in California, which was called Escalon. There was a parade going by and I remember there were two bands, they were both on the backs of trucks. And the first one was a rock band, with fairly long hair — it wasn't that long, but it was pretty long — and they had guitars and an electric bass and a generator on the back. And I remember not liking it very much. And then a bit later on, after the scouts had walked by, there was a jazz band on the truck, with the trombone player sitting on the back.

MR: On the tailgate.

TB: Yeah, on the tailgate. And a piano. And I thought wow, this is it. I want to do what they do. And that was my first taste of jazz of any kind. But it really wasn't until I got to Australia that I started playing any.

MR: But what was the next instrument after the piano?

TB: It was the trumpet. And that was in high school. Well what do you have four years in high school? The fourth year I bought a trumpet or a cornet and got into the band. I'd been in the choir for four years, so I had ear training and I could read music, and I knew where I was supposed to be in the choir and all that, but playing the trumpet in the band was a lot of fun, especially marching. I loved marching in a band on the street — Sousa marches around the town and on the football field. That was a lot of fun. And then when I got into college, into junior college, my parents decided that my teeth stuck out too much, like a beaver. So I had to have braces on my teeth, which is — have you ever tried playing trumpet with braces on your teeth?

MR: No, but my daughter has.

TB: Yeah. It's awful really. So I had to go into euphonium, which is a bigger mouthpiece. And for a couple of years I went off the trumpet. And then, about that time, we moved to Australia, and the braces came off. So I started playing the real stuff.

MR: Is it a trick to go from one to the other? Physically?

TB: Not for me. Not now. Now playing more than one instrument, my first other instrument besides the trumpet was the tuba. And I remember being in a band one night where the trombone player was doubling on sousaphone, on tuba. And when he went on to the trombone, nobody was playing the tuba. And I thought well, I asked the leader, is it okay, can I try this? And he says yeah — because it's just like a trumpet. You blow in it, it's got three valves, and at first it was a little weird but it took a couple of songs and then I learned you've got to relax your mouth, and then I got the notes. And it wasn't that hard. So the tuba, that was the next one, and if we're talking about some sort of chronology, the next instrument was the saxophone. And I was in England touring around and I was playing away and I felt this banging down here. And it was actually a hernia starting. And it got a little bit worse, and when I got back to Australia they said oh you'll have to have that operated on. So I did, and for two or three months after that it was really impossible to play the trumpet at first.

MR: Too much oomph down here? Too much pressure?

TB: Yeah. Well hernias, as well as other things, are congenital. In other words you inherit them from you parents, and my father had hernias too, and so does my brother. So now I've had two hernias and it just happen to happen while I was playing the trumpet. But while knitting up, while I've got the stitches there, you don't want to have any comedians around the house, you don't have any of the usual guys that come around and tell you

jokes, because you don't want to laugh, and you're careful not to cough or anything else. And playing the trumpet was definitely out. But saxophone you could play a little bit, in the end blow and work the fingers. So while I was convalescing I learned the saxophone.

MR: You just went out and picked up a saxophone?

TB: Yeah. A friend of mine was going overseas and I said leave it with me and I'll have a go, I've got to play something while you're gone.

MR: Well you definitely have some musical genes in your blood. I mean, being at this festival, the first night I heard you playing the trumpet. Last night and let's see this afternoon I heard you playing tenor sax. Later on in the day I heard you playing alto sax. And you seem to wail on all of them. Do you have a favorite?

TB: No.

MR: No?

TB: It all depends on the mood, and what kind of band it is. Really it's — that kind of band like the last one where I was playing alto, I wouldn't have wanted to play anything but alto. Because there was already a four-piece front line — there was trumpet, clarinet, trombone and tenor. So for me to double on any of those would have been not as fun as playing the alto. And trying to fit in, trying to play something that didn't get in their way. Because a five-piece front line is very difficult. But some bands you know you have to play the trumpet, other bands I want to play the clarinet, trombone's my newest one. I'm not there yet, but I'm working hard on it. But it just depends on the band and the mood.

MR: When I heard you play tenor, it was interesting because you were four of you together. And in my ears, you were the most aggressive player there. Do you agree with that?

TB: Yes.

MR: I mean you had Scott Hamilton and a couple of other guys who are mainstreamish players I guess — I don't know, labels are tough. But I almost could hear you playing in a rhythm & blues band too.

TB: Um hum. I probably get, if I got hot at all I get hot probably sooner, because I'm not used to playing — like Scott can play, he can go up in a very gradual incline and get hotter and hotter and hotter and hotter. And at the end of it, wow. I can't do that. I dive in with both feet and then I really can only play two or three choruses and then I run out of ideas. I need to do it more or something, or listen to Scott. But Harry Allen's great. He can start slow and then expand, and then you think he's going to stop and then he expands a bit more. And Scott Robinson, I'd never met Scott before. I'd never met Harry either. I've heard them on records but I've never met Scott. And he plays amazing eclectic things.

MR: He sure does.

TB: Doesn't he?

MR: Yes.

TB: You know, up high and down low. Perfect command of all the instruments, and he stands with a deadpan look — what's he going to do now? It's a lovely tone. He's completely in command of what he's doing. And he doesn't sound like anyone else either.

MR: So what kind of music did you listen to when you got into your teens? Did you get into jazz recordings?

TB: No, not at all until college. The first jazz, apart from this band that came by on the truck (I think they were playing "Saints" or something), the very first jazz I heard was Turk Murphy's band on the radio, from the University of the Pacific radio station. And shortly after that the family emigrated to Sydney and I started looking around for jazz. I was starting to collect '78s and I got a big job in a music store which was good. The whole idea was for me to go — we were going to settle in a city. We could build a boat anywhere — going back to the boat — we could build a boat anywhere, but we were going to go to a city where I could get into a conservatory and finish my degree. And it was a good theory, except we wrote to all of them and the only one that wrote back was the Sydney one, and they said yeah well we'll have a look at him. So when I got there they asked me questions like, "Well what syllabus have you been studying?" And I said, "What's a syllabus?" And they said, "Oh, well, what grade have you achieved?" "What do you mean what grade?" They asked me all these questions because the whole thing is built on the English system of grades and the syllabus means the program and, "What piece have you prepared?" and I hadn't prepared any piece. So I didn't fit in at all. And I left the conservatory with a kong — as we call it there — and got a job in a music store. And I got posted to the jazz department. And all of a sudden I was able to check out records every night — like two and three LP's. This was required, that you take home records and listen to them. Yeah. It was fantastic. So I took home everything, everything in the whole section, and taped everything. You weren't supposed to tape it, but I taped it of course, and brought it back the next day. So I had this vast collection of all these different things, and learned a lot at that time.

MR: What was the music scene like in Australia? You said this was early 70s?

TB: '72, '73.

MR: A pretty healthy pop scene over there?

TB: Yeah. A healthy pop scene but we didn't have anything to do with the pop scene at all. They still had black & white TV then. They didn't get color until about '74, just by the way. But they did have their own pop idols, which were a bit like the American ones. They had a small amateur, semi-pro jazz scene and I remember the salary, the money that we used to get on a Saturday night was seven dollars. And that went on for about two years, and then we got a rise, or raise, to eight. It went up a dollar.

MR: In a jazz club you're talking about?

TB: Bars.

MR: In bars.

TB: Real pubs. You know they open at eight in the morning and they close at eight at night and there's, you know, fights and stuff. There weren't jazz clubs as such, like they are here. But they had a jazz club, like a real club with members and they'd have meetings once a month. And there was a professional scene where guys would make studio records for commercials and jingles. But I never got into that until a lot later.

MR: Was it an event when an American jazz musician would come to town?

TB: Big event. I can remember the first concert I went to was — I mix them up — there were three concerts and I mix them up because they happened so close together, but I remember it was Earl Hines and Bobby Hacket, and Wild Bill Davison and Jon Faddis I think. Would he have been around in '72?

MR: Yup, um hum.

TB: All right, Jon Faddis, and gee, who else — Benny Goodman, Zoot Sims. There was one promoter that brought packages out. And just before I'd gotten there there was another package. It was New Orleans versus bebop, in one of those jazz war things, where they brought the Thelonious Monk band and Monk was so out of it he kind of didn't play for a few weeks, and George Lewis' band as well. And they toured together. And they'd appear on the same stage. So you'd get people from both camps coming along and sitting in different parts of the auditorium and booing the boppers.

MR: "And whose side are you on?"

TB: Oh yeah. Oh, you wouldn't speak to the other side. You'd know by the way you were dressed or, you know, what you were drinking or something. It was crazy. But yeah, any Americans that came to town — the Buddy Rich Big Band, Gary Burton came over, and the Basie Band came over once or twice. But of course, because Australia is so far away if musicians did a tour of Japan, sometimes they'd like go south and include Australia and New Zealand in their package. But we saw a fair bit of good talent, but not as much as I'd like.

MR: So did you get to a point where you found a few players on record that you really liked, and then you tried to emulate them, or were you pretty much —

TB: Oh, yeah.

MR: Like who?

TB: Well on different instruments, on trumpet I wanted to be Wingy Manone for a long time. You know, one arm.

MR: I'm glad you didn't take up that part of it.

TB: No, no, I started riding cable cars just kind of kidding myself that if I'd get it cut off I'd play better. But yeah, Wingy Manone was a hero, a trumpet player and of course Louis

Armstrong. I remember when I first got to Sydney playing in jazz band, I hadn't heard Louis Armstrong. I'd seen him on something like "The Dean Martin Show," a very late appearance, in maybe '71 or just before he died. And he didn't play, he just sang a bit of "Mame" or "Cabaret" or "Hello Dolly," or one of those things. And I thought, oh, that's Louis Armstrong? And so at the time my hero was Al Hirt. I remember kind of a dud banjo player who was the band leader, turned around after a couple of nights and said, "Well why don't you start listening to Louis Armstrong and get off Al Hirt?" I said, "Well I've heard Louis" you know, "he can't play." So he said, "You'd better get wise, you know, and listen to some of the right stuff." I said well maybe he's got something. Then somebody else laid the All Stars on me and Hot Five.

MR: There you go.

TB: Yeah. Everybody I listened to was an influence. Benny Carter on alto, and Hodges and Charlie Parker and Lester Young on tenor, and Chu Berry and Hawkins, and now all the guys on trombone. Pee Wee Russell on clarinet. Yeah. Take something from everybody.

MR: So do you work now, I hope this isn't an obvious question, do you work full time as a musician, as a performer?

TB: Yeah.

MR: And is there enough gigs in Australia that you can pretty much do all right?

TB: More than enough.

MR: No kidding?

TB: Yeah, there's lots. I could work more than I am. Because playing all the instruments, I get calls from more bands than like guys that just play one horn. Plus I lead two bands of my own and I'm in a big band. And it's a good thing Bob Barnard, because Bob is the king in Australia, you know, he's the man, he's out of the country a lot, which is good for me. So when they can't get Bob they ring me. And so I'm there a lot of the time. And we all do festivals in Melbourne and Adelaide, and interstate things, for pretty good money. So there's a lot going.

MR: Australia is very — there's a lot of distances between places, with not much in between them? Is that a fair statement?

TB: Oh, yeah. Well the nearest big city to Sydney is about 14 hours drive. And you've got some smaller ones in between, then the next one after that is 20 hours drive, then the next one after that — well it's Sydney, Melbourne, Adelaide, and then it's two days drive to Perth, which is the most remote city in the world. But yeah, the population now I think is about 15 million, which is really, it's not that many.

MR: That's not that much.

TB: But in the center, there's basically not much. It's real hot in most of the center, and where the rain is, on the east coast, where things grow and where people traditionally settled and

where they had the convict settlements in the old days, that's Sydney-Melbourne, and Adelaide, where the wine is. That southeastern coat. The northern part of it is too hot and it's rainy and Darwin's up there. We always say, "Darwin's got alcoholics unanimous." Because there's really nothing to do but drink and make money up there. So people go up for either one or the other. I've never been there, so I don't know. That's one of the Sydney sayings. But in the middle really it's basically nothing much. Little towns and towns in the desert with golf courses that don't have any grass, just sand. Well you have golfers.

MR: Have a sand wedge.

TB: A sand wedge, yeah, that's right.

MR: What do you think — did you miss much of America when you went to Australia?

TB: Yeah, for a long time I missed pine trees. Because I was a scout, you know. I mentioned the scouts marching by in the parade — I actually got up to be an Eagle Scout and so we went on lots of hikes and I spent a lot of time in the woods up around Lake Tahoe. And I love the forest. And in Australia they only have gum trees, you know, eucalyptus, which are different, they're kind of scraggly trees. And I missed the pine trees a lot, and I still do. And some of the food that you can get in America, like French's mustard, they don't have that down there.

MR: No kidding?

TB: Yeah. It's true. You get used to certain things when you're growing up here. Not much else.

MR: I hear you're quite a chef.

TB: I'm an amateur chef. I started when I was on the road and the only food you could get was pretty third rate, so I started cooking for myself and the guys in the band, in the motel rooms. You know you'd drive up to a motel and the guy'd come out and he'd always give you the coffee and the milk, so you could make your own tea in the room. The first thing they do is they give you the key, and a little jug of milk, when you'd check in. And he saw all the pots and pans and he says, "Oh you're not going to cook in there?" I said, "No, of course not." So we'd go straight into the — you know we'd always cook in the bathroom where it was tiles and they have like an air thing, and we'd make steaks and everything. And guys would come in and eat it. I learned to cook in the motels. But I like cooking all sorts of things — Indian food, and it's fun cooking Mexican food for people that have never had it. I mean it's different here where they're real connoisseurs, but over in Australia they talk about going out and having "taycos." Because, you know, they don't know how to pronounce it. So it's kind of fun.

MR: It must be hard to get some of the ingredients for some of that kind of thing.

TB: Yeah, it is. You have to really look. But Sydney's pretty cosmopolitan and there's a little pocket of Americans who've had a business selling, for instance, Mexican supplies, for a long time. There's four million people now in Sydney, and they're having the Olympics in the year 2000. So all the band leaders are thinking about, you know, what are we going to charge on New Years Eve in the year 2000, with the Olympics there? Will we start at two thousand dollars and go up? You think about these things.

MR: You take scale, and multiply it by — let's see —

TB: Just add on some aughts.

MR: Is there a strong musician's union in Australia?

TB: No. There used to be, but not anymore.

MR: It's kind of like here.

TB: I've heard, yeah. What were you going to say?

MR: Well, the musician's union is certainly not what it used to be. In the big cities it's still pretty powerful, but it has very little control over things that it used to — like what clubs will pay and all that kind of thing. Now it's mostly entrenched still in the symphony orchestras and TV and movies.

TB: Yeah. Guys that have really regular year to year employment with contracts.

MR: Yeah.

TB: Yeah it's the same down there too. You really get paid what you're worth in the jazz scene. In other words, if the people will come to hear you, you will get the job, and you'll get paid a commensurate fee.

MR: The state of jazz in Australia: what's the most contemporary thing that's going on? Does it pretty much follow what goes on in the States?

TB: I think so. The jazz education program there has a large bearing on the types of young people that come out. They go from high school to say the music programs in the colleges, and then out into the jazz workforce, if you like. And I think the way they teach jazz here is pretty much similar in the college here. It's pretty much similar to the way they do it over there. And I don't really think it's a good thing because the way they teach is — I don't really know what to say about that — but I've met a lot of young guys that have come up through jazz education courses and learned, and been in there for two or three years. And they don't know the basics. They don't know "Sweet Georgia Brown." They get embarrassed. They come and sit in with a swing band and you call "Sweet Georgia Brown" and they don't know it. I'm just touching on like sort of sore points here.

MR: They're not learning tunes, they're learning chords.

TB: They learn modes, they learn the chords, 2-5-1s, they learn how to improvise — I think the teachers — it's not the students' fault, it's the teachers' fault, and the people that design the curriculum, the curricula.

MR: The syllabi.

TB: The syllabi. There you go. And the teachers they get know what they know and they pay a bit of lip service to the old masters. They go back maybe as far as Charlie Parker and they might touch on the seminal influences before, and Louis Armstrong, Bix Beiderbecke, Lester Young and maybe Coleman Hawkins and probably speak about ragtime or something. They mention the Original Dixieland Jazz Band as being the first to record. But from what I gather from friends of mine who have gone through these courses, they really don't dwell on it enough. So the kids really don't have any idea. And they really get into the meat and potatoes of jazz, after Parker, like post-bebop they really start studying in the post-bebop period, because that's where the teachers come from. That's what they know. And these are the sort of players that you see come up. Until recently most of the young players in Sydney have been out of this kind of education system, this mold, and it's been the rare one that's been able to sidestep it. But there's a few guys that don't want to do that or can't do it. And they end up being professionals in our sort of thing. They can play traditional jazz. You know, if they play the trombone they know all about Kid Ory and they learn the proper songs and they don't try and play bebop over the wrong sorts of music. So it's a bit of a sore point with me there. Though I think the educational system is — getting back to the original question — probably similar to here.

MR: Okay. Is there an integrated jazz scene in Australia at all?

TB: How do you mean?

MR: I mean like black and white players?

TB: There aren't any black players. The aboriginals, they're there, but as far as I know there aren't any — there's been a few aboriginal tennis players, but they don't seem to be into jazz. There's quite a few country & western singers and guitar players, and there's a guy that comes along where we play on a Friday night with the didgeridoo.

MR: I was going to ask you when you might add that to your arsenal.

TB: Oh that's real hard.

MR: You can circular breathe and all that?

TB: I can circular breathe already on the trumpet. It's mind over matter, like learning to juggle three balls. Once you can do it it's easy. But you just have to keep your lips, you have to keep air going while you close your throat and breathe through your nose. You have to get somebody to show you, really, and then you'll know. But with the didgeridoo, the hole, it's not just a little hole like in the trumpet, or a straw or something, the hole is that big. And you're blowing a lot of air right through. And you have to breathe almost, it's continuous. Plus you've got to buzz and make this sound, and they're doing all these

things with their throat. And they're the most amazing sounds. Animal sounds and the sounds of the forests and birds and stuff, all from this pipe. Incredible.

MR: Yeah. I heard a fellow from Australia do it. He was aborigine and he went on for five, ten minutes. I was just enthralled.

TB: Did he play?

MR: He played amazingly. And he had titles for the songs. Like one was about a truck going down a highway in Australia and the things that it met.

TB: Oh, yeah?

MR: And as he did it, you could see, oh my God he's doing the truck and it's going to run over this animal here.

TB: Truck meets a kangaroo.

MR: Yeah. It was just uncanny.

TB: That's good.

MR: Yeah. I mean when we think of Australian music we probably think of, you know novelty songs, "Tie Me Kangaroo Down, Sport."

TB: Yeah, well, at one time that was true. I remember hearing that on the radio when I was young in the sixties. Rolf Harris. And actually I toured with Rolf Harris once.

MR: No kidding? That's a bit of trivia.

TB: Yeah, in Japan. You might have heard of James Morrison? Okay, he's a multi-talented instrumentalist who's worked with Ray Brown and the Philip Morris Superband and gee, all sorts of guys. And he's — wait a minute — can we cut there?

MR: Yeah.

TB: I just forgot what I was going to say.

MR: You were talking about James Morrison and playing with Rolph Harris.

TB: Rolf Harris. Okay. Sorry about that. Where shall I take it up?

MR: Well, we were just — I was mentioning how we don't have a very good conception of what goes on in Australia.

TB: You want to start that again?

MR: As far as music.

TB: When we think of Australian music, we think of novelty songs. Like "Tie Me Kangaroo Down, Sport."

MR: Well I happened to tour Japan with this multi-instrumentalist, James Morrison. And it was the expo in Tokyo, and every country had a week to do their own thing, present their own music and their food. And Rolf Harris was on the bill with us, along with Roger Woodward the pianist, and opera stars and a few other people. And Rolf did "Tie Me Kangaroo Down," and he played the wobble board, which was just a board — quite effective. And he did this thing where we played [sings] "Sakura" da da da da da you

know the Japanese theme. And he set out the front. And he'd do a watercolor, which was real good, and when we finished the tune, he finished the watercolor and signed it, and then proceeded to give it to these people in the front, for charity. And they'd auction it off and they'd get all this money. And he did this on every concert in Japan. He finished with a watercolor, and gave it to charity. So I thought that was a good thing to do. But I asked him about "Tie Me Kangaroo, Down" and he said, "Yeah, everybody thought that was the only Australian music, because it was the number one hit."

MR: Well there was also "My Boomerang Won't Come Back."

TB: Oh, yeah, yeah. "I've practiced 'till I was black in the face/my boomerang won't come back." You can't even mention that though these days. They never play that on the radio anymore.

MR: No, I guess not.

TB: Oh, it's politically very incorrect. But The Seekers, you know, they were Australian.

MR: Oh, yeah?

TB: And we heard them on the radio, and we didn't know. No one ever said they were Australian. We thought they were English.

MR: Well you have stated that you have a mission, according to the program here, and that's to keep the swing music alive of the '30s and '40s.

TB: Um hum.

MR: And what is it about this music — can you put into words — that makes you want to play it?

TB: It's just worth doing. A lot of times we just keep playing and there's nothing particular that inspires us to do it. It's a worthwhile, valid music, blah, blah, blah, but when it swings, when it really comes together, it's better than anything. And I've heard a little bit of that today, this morning. I mean you were sitting at the table. Were you there when they were playing —

MR: Those arrangements?

TB: Those arrangements. The last song they played, I was watching Bob Haggart. And I want to go right out and learn the bass now. I really do. Him and Hal Smith, they got together and that's as good as any jazz I've ever heard on a record.

MR: It has a pulse to it when it get going—

TB: Yeah.

MR: And especially with that acoustic rhythm guitar chunking away.

TB: Well even at its worst, it sounds good. But today, it caught fire. You know we can count on the fingers of both hands at my age, the times when that happens. And it doesn't happen that often, even if you play every night of the week for years and years. The times

when you can remember yourself rising up and thinking, this is jazz, this is why I'm doing it. And today was one of those things. My heart — wow. I wanted to yell.

MR: I know. And it was a little strange to sit while that was happening like that and to look at the audience and, God bless them, they support this music. But it seemed a little strange to just have everyone so still.

TB: It's not their fault they can't dance. They've got to sit still. If they had a dance floor, they'd be up. They should have a dance floor. This is dance music. We're playing dance music to people who are listening. And basically it's — I don't want to say it's wrong, but what we're doing, it's not concert music.

MR: It's selling it short, because that's what it was for.

TB: Selling it short — that's good.

MR: It's got that chunk-chunk beat, and I'm not even a dancer but I just felt like getting up.

TB: Oh, me neither.

MR: And I know a lot of those people would.

TB: I know they would. A concert's good every now and then to keep you honest. And when you know that everyone's listening it's great. And you put on a tie. But for day to day playing, if they're not dancing, you're really not sure if they like it or not. I mean we're pretty sure here that they like it, because they're here, and they keep showing up and they don't buzz off to some other place. They're there. But if people are dancing you can tell, you can create heat and make them dance harder — spin around, fall over, and all that. So that's really what this music is supposed to do, and we can't do it here and at the other jazz festivals. So I'd like to see them have a dance floor here.

MR: Tell me about this nice CD.

TB: That's my latest one, recorded in Australia with master cornet player Bob Barnard. And it's called "The Man From the South," which is a tune taken from a Ted Weems recording from 1927. There's a picture of my car on the front, I'm sitting on my car, which is a 1953 Holden, a brand that will probably be unfamiliar to all the listeners, probably apart from expatriates.

MR. Is it a V-8?

TB: No. It's what they call a small 6, which is as big as you got in those days. Ford had a V-8 but then it cost more. But this was built in Australia and everyone was really proud of it.

MR: And you play trombone, and cornet and you do some vocal, some tenor sax. Well I'll look forward to hearing this.

TB: Yeah. There's a clarinet track, I sing a couple, Bob sings one or two.

MR: And you do some arrangements too.

TB: Yep. And it's out on a label called LaBrava, which is run by the brother of my fiance.

MR: You get distribution across Australia — I mean is that the goal? It's kind of hard sometimes promoting your own records.

TB: Yeah it is. You sell more of them on the gig. David tries his best to contact, he's got lots and lots of CDs to sell and they're all really well done, etcetera, etcetera. But he tries to put them in record stores and the mainstream record stores don't really want to know. All the jazz record stores said fine, but if it's not the large selling things, they might keep a couple of copies, and when those go they don't bother reordering because they forget. So distribution is tough, really tough.

MR: What's the most contemporary — oh I don't want to use that word, let me use a different word — what's the most modern, chronologically, type of jazz you would care to play?

TB: Gee. Probably Charlie Parker style bebop. That era. Forties bebop. And also I really like the cool school — the Art Pepper, Paul Desmond, Gerry Mulligan stuff — maybe being a west coast boy, I've really got an affinity for that. But I really like that. But the hard bop stuff I can't understand and certainly the modal thing from the 60s and all that free stuff, I can't say I don't like it, but I can't do it. I've tried, but I can't do it.

MR: Can you think of the weirdest, toughest gig that you've ever played?

TB: Well I can think of some weird gigs. Once a band I took from Sydney up to a place we call the Gold Coast, which is Casino World above Sydney and they have American style casinos. A band of mine had trumpet, trombone, clarinet, banjo, piano and washboard. It was supposed to be a kind of background, good time band for a couple of nights. And when we got there, the man from the hotel said, "Okay, the acts will be coming along any minute with the charts." And I though uh oh. And so along came this guy who was straight out of Atlantic City or Vegas or something, and he had all these charts for things — Pointer Sisters medleys and all this stuff. And there was no other band, and he was booked, and we were booked, and nobody told him and nobody told us. And fortunately the piano player and I both read music. No one else in the band did. And this was washboard — there's no drums. And there's a drum chart this long.

MR: "I'm so excited—"

TB: Can you imagine? With the lights and all of that? So we did the show, and he left out the things that were impossible, like things with long drum fills. So that's one of the weirdest ones. We got through it, and he thanked us at the end. He said, "Look, I know you did your best." We said, "Well thanks for putting up with us." We both split real quick for the bar and got away.

MR: Wow. Is the life of a jazz musician these days, is it a healthy lifestyle?

TB: Well, healthy in what way?

MR: Well I'm just thinking, you know we were talking about the bebop era and so forth. And so many of those guys —

TB: Oh you mean healthy drug-wise?

MR: Yeah.

TB: It's as healthy as you want it to be. I think it was always healthy. There were guys that did it all without drugs, apparently Clifford Brown did everything without being a junkie or without drinking a whole lot. Other guys just got on the bandwagon and did it. And there are guys now that it's not so much heroin going around, certainly not in our scene, there's no junkies. There's a lot of alcoholics, and a lot of guys that smoke too much. But basically it's a healthy scene, yeah.

MR: Good.

TB: We still work in places where they serve alcohol, and places that are full of smoke, far from here at the jazz party where there's no smoke. So it's not all that healthy that way. You know, you're forced to breathe smoke. And you're not forced to drink alcohol but it's there and you tend to go with the flow.

MR: Okay. Well good. I just want you to stay healthy now.

TB: Well I'm going to try.

MR: To carry all those instruments around.

TB: It's the worst thing about being a multi-instrumentalist. You've got to carry them.

MR: Yeah. Especially when you're coming from there to here, and back and planes and all that kind of stuff.

TB: Yeah. I've got one bag with my clothes and CDs. And then you've got an option — you have to take no more than two bags. So trombone is bag number two. And then you've got to carry the others on your shoulders and do some fast explaining at the door about why you've got three cases, and none of them fit in the little thing, and you say "well please, my livelihood depends on this and won't you put it in the suit closet?" And they take pity on you. But you're always doing this.

MR: Yeah.

TB: So it helps if you wear a tie and don't look like a bum.

MR: Well I want to thank you for joining us today. It's been a pleasure. And I wish you the best. You are traveling straight back to Australia or are you here for a while?

TB: No, I'm actually going on the train, on Monday, with Dan Barrett to New York, and we're going to hang out as they say, and we're meeting Bob Barnard on Tuesday night, and then I have to fly to Europe for two or three weeks worth of gigs over there. I've been going to Europe every year for almost twenty years, playing with Dutch bands. There's a couple of bands that don't have trumpet players — Dixieland bands.

MR: Did you ever run into Spiegle Willcox over there?

TB: I met him once. Yeah.

MR: Yeah? He lives not too far from us and is still doing well at 93 or so.

TB: Where does he live?

MR: He lives in Cincinnatus, New York, which is an hour and a half south of — it's right in the middle of New York State. He's got a beautiful home. Cool guy.

TB: How old is he now? Like 90 or something?

MR: He's definitely over 90.

TB: I wonder if he's as old as Benny Waters.

MR: I think Benny Waters is 94, and I think he's tops.

TB: 94. Right. I'm doing a festival with Dan Barrett and some Dutchmen next March. That's the next time I'll be in the States. The Arbors Jazz Party.

MR: Yes. We're thinking of going there.

TB: Yeah. In Florida, Clearwater Bay, Clearwater Beach? Yeah, I'll be there, we'll see you there.

MR: Good folks that run that thing, too.

TB: Yeah, Mat Domber, the head of the records. I spoke to him on the phone, sounds like a good cat.

MR: He is.

TB: Right.

MR: Well thanks for your time. I hope you have good music tonight.

TB: Thanks for having us, Monk.

MR: Okay.